Lancaster University College
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Reading Texts

Text A

New study finds it's harder to turn off a robot when it's begging for its life

Paragraph 1 Robots designed to interact socially with humans are slowly becoming more common. They are appearing as receptionists, tour guides, security guards, and porters. But how good are we at treating these robots *as* robots? A growing body of evidence suggests not good at all. Studies have repeatedly shown we are extremely susceptible to social cues coming from machines. A recent experiment by German researchers demonstrates that people will even refuse to turn a robot off — if it begs for its 'life'.

Paragraph 2 Research led by Horstmann *et al.* (2018) from the University of Duisburg-Essen was recently published in the journal *PLOS One*. In the study, 89 volunteers were recruited to complete a pair of tasks with the help of Nao, a small humanoid robot. The participants were told that the tasks (which involved answering a series of either / or questions, like 'Do you prefer pasta or pizza?' and organizing a weekly schedule) were to improve Nao's learning algorithms. This was just a cover story, however, and the real test came after these tasks were completed, and scientists asked participants to turn off the robot.

Paragraph 3 In roughly half of the experiments, the robot protested, telling participants it was afraid of the dark and even begging: 'No! Please do not switch me off!' When this happened, the human volunteers were likely to refuse to turn the bot off. Of the 43 volunteers who heard Nao's pleas, 13 refused. The remaining 30 took, on average, twice as long to comply as those who did not hear the desperate cries at all.

Paragraph 4 When questioned about their actions, participants who refused to turn the robot off gave a number of reasons for doing so. Some said they were surprised by the pleas; others said that they were scared they were making a mistake. But the most common response was simply that the robot had said it didn't *want* to be switched off, so who were they to argue? As the study's authors, Horstmann *et al*. (2018) state: 'Triggered by the objection, people tend to treat the robot as a real person rather than as a machine by following, or at least considering following, its request to stay switched on.'

Paragraph 5 This finding builds on a larger theory known as 'the media equation' established by the psychologists, Reeves and Mass (1996). The media equation theorized that humans tend to treat non-human media (which includes TV, film, computers, and robots) as if they are human. We talk to machines, reason with our radios, and console our computers.

Paragraph 6 Various studies since have shown how this principle affects our behaviour, especially when it comes to interactions with robots. Lee, Pen and Yan (2006) revealed that we are more likely to enjoy interacting with a bot that we perceive as having the same personality type as us, and we'll happily associate machines with gender stereotypes. We observe what's known as the 'rule of reciprocity' when interacting with robots (meaning we tend to be nice to them when they're nice to us) and will even take orders from one if it's presented as an authority figure.

Paragraph 7 This is not the first time the 'begging computer does not want to die' scenario has been tested. Similar research was carried out in 2007 by Bartneck and Van der Hook, from Eindhoven University of Technology in The Netherlands with a robot resembling a cat that also pleaded for its life. Participants were forced to turn it off by observing scientists and all of them did — but not before going through a serious moral struggle. In a video clip of the experiment, you can see the robot asking a volunteer: 'You're not really going to switch me off, are you?' The human says: 'Yes, I'm sorry, I have to' - while struggling to do so.

Paragraph 8 The new study builds on this earlier work by using a greater number of participants. It also tested whether it made a difference if the robot was shown to have social skills before it asked not to be turned off. In some of the trials, Nao expressed opinions to the human volunteers, told jokes, and shared personal information. Surprisingly, this social behaviour did not have a huge effect on whether the volunteers 'spared' Nao.

Paragraph 9 So what does all this mean for our machine-filled future? Are we destined to be manipulated by socially sophisticated bots that know how to push our buttons? According to Horstmann, it's something we need to be aware of, but it's not a huge threat. In other words: get used to turning off machines, even if they don't appear to like it. They're silicon and electricity, not flesh and blood.

Source:

Vincent, J. (2018).

Text B

The socio-cultural costs and benefits of tourism

Paragraph 1 Wide cultural differences occur between different countries and sometimes between different regions within the same country. Indeed, the existence of such differences may be one of the key reasons a tourism industry exists, as people wish to explore places and cultures different to their own. In some developing countries, the traditional cultural behaviour and traditional celebrations of particular groups of people are a focus of the tourism industry (Butler and Hinch, 1996). Sometimes, however, differences in cultural behaviour between visitors and residents are so great that mutual understanding is impossible.

Paragraph 2 The problem is worsened because tourists are, by definition, strangers in the destination. Their dress codes and patterns of behaviour are different to the residents. More importantly though, tourists' behaviour in a foreign place is often different to behaviour they would exhibit at home: excessive consumption of alcohol and drugs, violence and sometimes vandalism occur. As strangers, tourists are also vulnerable and fall victim to robbery and crimes perpetrated by the local community who may see these activities as a way to redress the balance.

Paragraph 3 When the cultural distinctions between the residents and tourists from richer countries and regions are strongly marked, local culture and customs may be exploited to satisfy the visitor, sometimes at the expense of local pride and dignity. McCannell (1993) explains that in order to try to protect the real local culture, the practice of 'staged authenticity' is used. 'Staged authenticity' is when the host country aims to convince tourists that festivals and activities in public areas such as hotel lobbies or restaurants are authentic and thus keep tourists away from more private local celebrations and residents' homes.

Paragraph 4 'Alternative tourism' seeks to address some of these issues but brings its own problems as the tourists are encouraged to penetrate the local culture. For example, the past decade has seen a rise in tours of townships in South Africa, with wealthy tourists viewing the local residents as if they are visiting a zoo. With good management and planning, it is possible for tourism to help preserve ancient cultures, but unfortunately, all too often the local way of life becomes a commercial version of its former self. Weiner (2011) highlighted that cheap imitations of traditional costumes and the skilled craftwork are often made to satisfy the needs of the visitor; while this provides a way for local people to obtain money with little effort, it diminishes the culture.

Paragraph 5 In primitive and isolated areas, the arrival of too many visitors can even cause local people to leave their settlements and move to new areas where they can remain undisturbed.

To combat this, in vulnerable areas such as North American Indian reservations, governing rules for visitors have been put in place. In some cases, the introduction of new rules due to tourism has completely changed the way of life of the local people. The institution of the national park system in some parts of Africa, although justifiable on the grounds of wildlife conservation and tourism, has seriously affected the hunting and nomadic existence of the local people (Brown and Hicks, 2009).

Paragraph 6 Accommodating tourists can also lead to environmental problems. This sometimes occurs as a result of the creation of National Parks. In Canada, the creation of tourist nature parks at Forillon and Gros Morne led to soil erosion, flooding and, in a recent case, mudslips, causing substantial loss of life and damage to property. Furthermore, the tourists themselves are often guilty of destroying the surrounding environment. In many areas, tourists sometimes ignorantly, sometimes deliberately, damage crops, frighten farm animals and leave large quantities of rubbish. From one mountain alone in Great Britain during the summer months, almost a tonne of litter a day (mainly discarded lunch wrappings) is brought down from the summit, whilst from the New Forest in Southern England, approximately 25,000 empty bottles are retrieved each year (Smith, 2011). In Australia, Baxter and Keen (2010) report that wildlife has been severely disturbed, coral reefs have been damaged and alien forms of plant life have been introduced into delicate ecosystems carried on the shoes and clothing of visitors.

Paragraph 7 If the picture appears too bleak, it should be remembered that tourism, both domestic and international, is at the same time a positive force in helping to protect the environment of the holiday regions. Many of the disadvantages mentioned above can be offset by high quality planning, design and management, and by educating tourists to appreciate the environment. Tourists are attracted to areas of natural beauty, regions of historical and architectural interest and areas with abundant and interesting wildlife. Some of the money spent by tourists in the region, in particular the money received from entry fees, can be used to conserve and improve the natural environment (as is the case for example in the Kenyan game reserves). The extent and nature of the environmental and ecological damage done by tourists is related to the magnitude of the development and the volume of visitors, the nature of the environment in question, and the nature of the planning and management practices adopted before and after development takes place.

Source:
Theobald, W. (2013)